

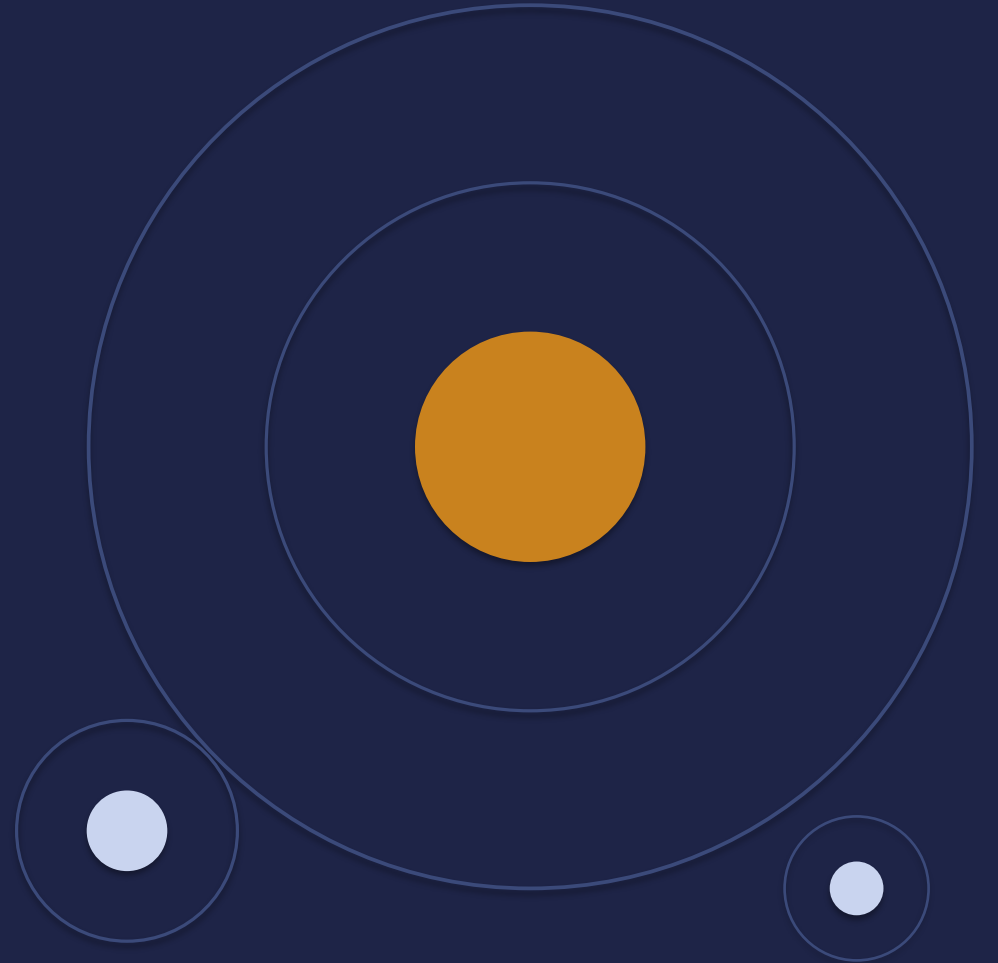
MADHYASTH DARSHAN · CO-EXISTENTIALISM

Why Humans Are Not Just Material

One question, three explanatory frameworks — Madhyasth Darshan, physicalism, and Advaita Vedanta

A comparative study of lived experience, ontology, evidence, and testability

Primary texts of Madhyasth Darshan, by Shri A. Nagraj — MVD · SB · JV (tr. Rakesh Gupta)





THE QUESTION

Is a Human Just a Body?

Physics describes the body's composition and dynamics with extraordinary success. The unresolved step is whether those descriptions exhaust sentience, selfhood, value, and agency.



Science / physicalism

Science maps brain–body dependence; physicalism adds that the person is wholly reducible to physicochemical organisation.



Madhyasth Darshan

A human is a material body joined with jeevan, a real sentient unit. 'Not just material' rejects reduction to an insentient body; it does not reject matter.



Advaita Vedanta

The empirical person is body–mind, but the true Self is nondual awareness. The world is mithya: dependently real, not absolutely real.

Shared experience does not decide ontology. Each view must show why its further inference is warranted.



ORIENTATION

How We'll Compare the Three Views

Keep the lived data fixed, then compare what each framework adds to explain it.

1

Lived data

Separate the experiences needing explanation from any claim about their ultimate cause.

2

Madhyasth model

Examine body + jeevan, the four orders, and the proposed conduct-based test.

3

Scientific evidence

Distinguish measured brain–body dependence from the physicalist claim of sufficiency.

4

Advaita model

Examine witness, koshas, mithya, and the inference from awareness to Brahman.

5

Compare and test

Ask what each view explains, assumes, predicts, and leaves open.



Four Experiences That Need Explanation

Phenomenology identifies the explananda; it does not by itself prove jeevan.



Two modes of fulfilment

Food, rest, and safety answer bodily need; understanding, trust, and justice answer a different demand. The distinction is real even if its cause remains disputed.



Wanting outruns need

Human desire can become indefinite—wealth, status, certainty, happiness. This exceeds immediate need but can be explained in more than one way.



Self exceeds a snapshot

We speak of ‘my body’ and persist through sleep, growth, and change. That raises a continuity question; it does not yet establish a non-material substance.



Early moral expectations

Children show expectations of fairness and care early. Developmental evidence constrains explanations; it does not settle whether the source is innate, social, or jeevan.



Real Experiences, Embodied Explanations

Science establishes systematic dependence of experience on brain and body. Physicalism interprets that dependence as ontological sufficiency; that further step is philosophical.

Two fulfilments remain embodied

Interoception, reward, attachment, and cultural learning can differentiate bodily and relational fulfilment without a second entity.

Unlimited wanting is learnable

Reinforcement, prediction, language, and social comparison can extend desire far beyond immediate biological need.

The self is modelled

Memory, embodied prediction, and social cognition can sustain a coherent self-model across bodily change.

Morality develops early

Evolution, temperament, attachment, and learning can produce early fairness expectations without assuming jeevan.

Public evidence shows neural dependence. It has not yet derived subjective experience, normativity, or agency from physics alone.



Neti Neti — Not This, Not This

Turn attention inward and distinguish seer from seen (drig-drishya-viveka). Whatever appears as an object—including body, thought, and ego—is not the ultimate subject.



Witness, not content

Fulfilment, wanting, and ego are observed and therefore not the ultimate Self. Deep sleep is recalled as an absence of differentiated experience; Advaita reads it with waking and dream as evidence across states.



Threefold discipline

Hearing (shravana), reasoning (manana), and sustained meditation (nididhyasana) under a qualified teacher—not introspection alone—support the tradition's conclusion.

Advaita regards jeevan as still an observable individual principle; MD regards the enduring self and plural world as real. The dispute is where negation should stop.



Body + Jeevan, in One Real World



The answer

A human is the temporary joint form of a material body and jeevan, a sentient atom. Both are real units: anti-reductionist, but not Cartesian substance dualism.



A model, not a gap-filler

The body supplies structure and physiological activity; jeevan is proposed to account for experience, appraisal, desire, and understanding. The distinction still requires evidence.

“Existence is not just physicochemical matter, but all physical, chemical and jeevan entities are inseparably present in Omnipresence.”

— MVD, The Alternative, point 7

Matter develops through compositional orders; jeevan is claimed to arise through a distinct atomic completion. These are separate claims.



Four Orders of Nature

MD describes four compositional orders. Animal and knowledge orders are sentient because a body is joined with jeevan; ‘order’ names organisation and activity, not four substances nested inside one another.

Material

composes, decomposes

Soil, water, metals, and other material formations.

Biological / prana

grows, reproduces

Growth and reproduction in plant bodies.

Animal

selects, senses

Jeevan joined with an animal body.

Knowledge

imagines, evaluates, understands

Human body + jeevan; conduct is the central test.

A higher order depends on lower material composition; this does not make jeevan a product of that composition.

The knowledge order is distinguished by the possibility of understanding and responsible conduct—not by biological complexity alone.



Sentience and the Claim of Atomic Completion

MD does not derive jeevan from biological complexity; it proposes a distinct atomic threshold and history.



Sentient atom

Jeevan is claimed to be a constitutionally complete atom with irreducible powers of desire, thought, and expectation.



Latency

A jeevan not joined to a suitable body is inferred to remain inactive or latent. This protects continuity but is not independently observed.

Post-death continuity follows within the theory; evidence for it must be distinguished from the theory's internal fit.



One Joint Form, Two Explanatory Roles



Different roles need explanation

Digestion, circulation, and neural activity belong to the body; imagination, appraisal, and understanding are attributed to jeevan. This illustrates the proposal—it does not independently prove two entities.



Joint form, not a pilot

MD describes coexistence and mutual participation: neither a ghost pushing matter nor identity of mind with brain. A detailed causal model remains an open requirement.



Koshas are not a one-to-one map

MD's bodily and conscious layers can be compared with Advaita's five sheaths, but the systems differ in number, function, and ontology.

“The body is not jeevan, and jeevan is not the body. Jeevan is eternal, and the body is merely a vehicle and medium for jeevan.”

— SB, Ch. 7



SCIENCE · ONTOLOGY

The Physicalist Answer



The answer

A human is an evolved organism whose mental capacities depend wholly on biological organisation. Science supports pervasive dependence; physicalism adds the ontological claim.



Method

Public measurement, modelling, and replication; explanations begin with organised matter and neural function.

Five replies to the Madhyasth ontology



Continuity, not four orders

Gradients of organisation; no sentient threshold observed



Mind emerges from organisation

Destroy the organisation and mental functions cease



No second entity

No independent sentient unit has been detected



Culture + brain, not a knower

Brains in social worlds support symbol use and culture



Layered function, not koshas

Distributed bodily, cortical, and subcortical functions



The Interaction Problem

The serious challenge is not that an extra cause must obviously violate energy conservation. Conservation laws constrain measured systems; they do not by themselves prove causal closure.



The physicalist challenge

If jeevan changes bodily action, specify the mechanism and show effects not already explained by neural dynamics. Without a distinct prediction, the added entity risks explanatory idleness.



The Madhyasth reply—and its burden

The proposal is joint activity, not an external force. But naming a joint form is not yet a causal account; conditions, pathways, and discriminating observations are still needed.

A useful test must compare rival predictions—not simply restate either ontology.



What Science Explains—and What Remains Open



Neural dependence is strong

Lesions, stimulation, drugs, development, and imaging show that experience and cognition vary systematically with brain and body.



Explanatory entailment is open

Dependence does not yet explain why physical processing is accompanied by experience, nor how reasons and values become causally effective.

The hard problem and the Madhyasth rahasyata both mark an explanatory gap; naming the gap does not decide what fills it.

MD offers jeevan where physicalism demands mechanism. Physicalism offers brain dependence where MD owes discriminating evidence. Each presses where the other is least complete.



You Are Not Even an Individual

Advaita distinguishes empirical from ultimate reality. The world is mithya: not sheer nonexistence, but dependent reality whose being is not separate from Brahman.



Only Brahman is ultimately real

Atman is Brahman; plurality is valid within empirical life but lacks independent ultimate reality.



Not the body — or the mind

Body, life-force, mind, intellect, and the bliss sheath are successively negated as not-Self.



Witness to nonduality

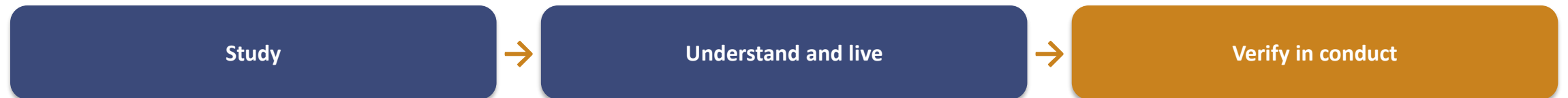
Distinguishing witness from witnessed begins the inquiry; Upanishadic testimony and reasoning support identity with Brahman. Introspection alone does not yield that second step.

Ultimately no separate material human exists; empirically, embodiment, ethics, learning, and suffering still matter.



How Madhyasth Darshan Asks to Be Tested

Nagraj reports that samadhi did not disclose the unknown; he locates the decisive discovery in samyama and presents the result for study, practice, and verification.



Textual testimony initiates inquiry; understanding and conduct are supposed to yield pramanikta. The aspiration is intersubjective, but controls, failure criteria, and replication remain underspecified.

Does understanding reliably produce justice, trust, responsibility, and mutual fulfilment—and distinguish the theory from rival psychological or ethical accounts?



COMPARING THE THREE VIEWS

One Question, Three Answers

	SCIENCE / PHYSICALISM	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta
What is a human?	Embodied organism; physicalism says wholly physical	Body + plural jeevan in joint form	Empirical body–mind; true Self = Brahman
Is the world real?	Physical world is ontologically basic	Real units in coexistence	Mithya: dependently real, not absolute
Consciousness?	Brain-dependent; realised by organisation	Irreducible power of jeevan	Awareness is fundamental; mind reflects it
How many selves?	Many organisms and persons	Many enduring jeevans	One Self ultimately
Survives death?	Person ends; physical components continue	Body decomposes; jeevan continues	No birth or death for the Self
Method	Measurement, modelling, prediction	Text, understanding, lived conduct	Scripture, reason, meditation

Science supplies evidence; physicalism is one ontological interpretation of it.



COMPARING THE THREE VIEWS

Three Contrasts That Cannot Be Blended Away



Real plurality or nonduality

MD affirms many real units; madhyasth names a mediative or regulative role. Advaita accepts plurality empirically, not ultimately.



Individual self or one Self

MD keeps many jeevans and individual responsibility. Advaita treats individuality as superimposed on nondual awareness.



How consciousness relates to matter

Physicalism: organised brain. MD: body + jeevan. Advaita: awareness is prior and matter is dependent.

MD joins physicalism in affirming a real shared world and joins Advaita in rejecting reduction of awareness to matter—but its ontology is not a compromise.

The views overlap at points; their ultimate commitments remain incompatible.



CRITICAL REVIEW

Each Strong Inside, Vulnerable Outside

Madhyasth Darshan

Integrates self, value, conduct, and nature in one system; offers a public-facing ideal of verification.

Atomic transition, latency, post-death continuity, and body–jeevan causation lack independent, discriminating evidence.

Scientific materialism

Best-supported account of brain–mind dependence; precise, cumulative public methods.

Reduction from physical process to subjectivity, normativity, and agency remains unfinished; closure is often assumed rather than measured.

Advaita Vedanta

Powerful analysis of witness and content; mature discipline of inquiry, ethics, and contemplative practice.

Introspection does not by itself establish Brahman or nonduality; empirical plurality and suffering must not be rhetorically erased.

No view wins by identifying another's gap; each must support its own positive inference.



THE BOTTOM LINE

What Evidence Could Change the Balance?

The three views make claims at different levels. A fair test must target the claim it can actually bear on.

What would actually move the debate:

- **Neural sufficiency**
If controlled neural models predict conscious report, learning, and agency without residue, the motivation for jeevan weakens—but metaphysical identity still does not follow automatically.
- **Distinct jeevan effects**
Reliable effects that require the body–jeevan model and resist neural or psychological alternatives would strengthen MD. Mere correlation with practice would not.
- **Advaita's inference**
Contemplative reports can test reproducibility and transformation; establishing nondual Brahman additionally requires philosophical warrant.

Each result should update only the claim it addresses. No single anomaly or successful mechanism settles every metaphysical question.

WHY HUMANS ARE NOT JUST MATERIAL

Same Human Experience, Three Explanatory Commitments

- **Science**
Shows pervasive dependence of mind on brain and gives the strongest public method; physicalism interprets this as sufficiency.
- **Madhyasth Darshan**
Proposes a real body + jeevan joint form and makes conduct central; its atomic and causal claims remain open to stronger tests.
- **Advaita Vedanta**
Locates identity in nondual awareness and treats the world as dependently real; the witness-to-Brahman step carries the heaviest philosophical burden.

Keep the phenomenological data fixed, separate evidence from inference, and ask which ontology explains more with fewer unsupported commitments.

